

Why Does Praying in Tongues Edify Us?

Yesterday, from the book of Jude, we found out that you and I should earnestly contend for the faith that was once delivered to the saints. But we found out more than that. Jude would not tell us to contend without going on in detail to show us how.

He said certain men crept in unawares. Whoever these men were, they destroyed the faith of the early church.

He likened them to clouds without water. When they come over the horizon, they look good, sound good, and put on quite a show. But when they get overhead, they cannot produce because they have no water.

In contending for the faith, Jude went on to say you do not have to be like these clouds without water, sensual and sense-ruled, because you have the Holy Ghost.

Because you have the Holy Ghost, you can build yourselves up above a walk dominated by your senses into a glorious, liberated walk of power by praying in the Holy Ghost.

We found out for sure that praying in tongues is a major key to this walk of the Spirit, this walk of power.

When I first became infatuated with tongues as a language for edification, I wanted to find out all I could about it.

So I went to those who seemed to be somewhat among them and said, "How come praying in tongues builds us up on our most holy faith? How does it increase our faith?"

As far as I knew, faith came only one way. It comes by hearing, and hearing, and hearing by what the Word of God says about your problem, not the flesh, not the devil, not the world, but God.

So I asked them, "What does speaking a bunch of syllables in the air have to do with increasing anyone's faith?"

They said, "Well, brother, have you not read the Word?"

I said, "I hope so."

"We are edified when we pray in tongues."

I said, "I know that. I can read. What I want to know is why we are edified."

"Have you broken the word edified down in the Greek?"

"I guess I have, just like everybody else."

"It means to receive a charge."

I said, "How so?"

"Faith is a tangible substance."

"Yes."

"You are receiving a charge."

"How?"

They said, "It would be correct to say the man put positive and negative cables on your car battery and edified it."

I said, "You mean charged it?"

"Yes, edified it."

I accepted that third-grade explanation for many years. The reason was that in the first crusade I went into after being locked up for three months in the prayer closet edifying, I laid hands on a woman. In the middle of my prayer she left. I thought, "Uh-oh." But when I opened my eyes, she was lying on the floor.

I thought, "My God, positive, negative. How do you like that for being charged?"

I accepted that explanation for years because a lot of teaching was going around about faith being a tangible substance that can be transferred by the laying on of hands, which is correct.

But I still could not get away from the fact that faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God. How did speaking in tongues into the air have to do with my increase of faith?

I knew my faith was being increased, but I did not know why.

This is the question the whole church world that does not speak with tongues has been asking those of us who do.

"Are you charismatic?"

"Yes."

"Do you speak with tongues?"

"Yes."

"Why do you do that?"

"Well, it is the initial evidence that you are filled with the Holy Ghost."

"Are you telling me I am not?"

"No, I did not say that. It edifies us."

"How come?"

"You just pray in tongues, and it edifies you."

"Why does it do that?"

"It charges you up."

"Why does it do that?"

"Take it by faith like we did."

We have not been able to tell them. If we had been able to tell them, a whole lot more of them would have been beating our door down to get what we have.

Instead, we mishandled the Holy Spirit. We brought so much flesh into it that they do not want what we have.

Psychiatrists say, "You weird people."

I beg your pardon. That is peculiar. Peculiar does not mean weird. It means you eat when nobody else does. When famine is killing everybody, you do not die. That is what peculiar means.

We mishandled the Holy Spirit and brought in so much flesh. It is all inspired by the devil. I am not saying you are of the devil. I am saying the misuse is inspired by the devil.

I used to think I would recognize the Holy Ghost in heaven because He would be that finely dressed gentleman, the third in the Godhead, standing behind Jesus. The moment I walked into heaven, He would extend His hand and say, "Aloha, in the name of My name!"

I would say, "You are the Holy Ghost. I can tell by Your accent."

I would turn on some preacher on television and think, "Why can he not preach normal? What is wrong with him?"

They say, "It is the anointing, brother."

No. It is their reaction to the anointing, passed on by their fathers in that particular church.

The forefathers were preaching machines. They could preach hellfire and brimstone so powerfully you would run to the altar. They preached to thousands with no microphones, and they always preached to the back row. They would preach all their air out.

Then came the microphone, and the second generation thought the sound was the anointing.

I almost did not get saved because Sister Chickenwalker was up front when the Holy Ghost came on her. I said, "What is wrong with that woman's neck?"

If the Holy Ghost is really on someone, we should not blame fleshly jerking on God. The Holy Ghost is pure. He is power. He is wisdom. He is the revealing of God in you. He is so decent and in order it would make you and me sick.

Do I go wild and dance? You bet, as much as they do at any football game. But I am not blaming spastic flesh on God.

Can you imagine how I felt when God began to open up 1 Corinthians 14? I kept asking Him, "I know my faith has been increased. Would You please show me how?"

When the Holy Spirit opened this chapter, I took the first step into the rest of my life. I took my first step into a deliberate, premeditated walk into the power of God, just because I wanted to.

First Corinthians 14:1 says:

Follow after charity,
and desire spiritual gifts,
but rather that ye may prophesy.

Charity means love in action. Paul was not saying prophecy was greater than speaking in tongues. He was writing to the Corinthian church and exhorting them as individuals to excel to a place in God where they edified the whole church.

In order to teach them how to do this, he had to differentiate between prophecy, tongues with interpretation, and tongues for personal edification.

Because he had to differentiate between tongues for edification and tongues with interpretation that equal prophecy, I get to sit in on his explanation of tongues for edification. When I did, I discovered why we experience such a tremendous increase of faith from praying in the Holy Ghost.

Verse 2 says:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God:
for no man understandeth him;
howbeit in the spirit
he speaketh mysteries.

When Dave Roberson speaks in an unknown tongue, he speaks not unto men, but unto God.

Why does nobody understand me? Because I am not speaking with tongues to be interpreted by you. I am speaking in tongues for personal edification. This verse declares that I am talking to God. It is not for your interpretation. It is none of your business.

This is between me and my Father God. It is my human spirit in divine communication with God Himself.

With my physical man, I contact physical things. With my soul, my mind, will, intellect, and emotions, I communicate with my fellow man. Jesus revealed that God is Spirit, and those who worship Him must worship Him in spirit and in truth.

When I speak with tongues, instantly my human spirit makes direct contact with God.

If I called Ronald Reagan and he answered the phone, I would faint. Yet there is One who administrates over the universe and over the life of every believer who will allow Him, and still He has time when Dave Roberson speaks with tongues to pick up the red telephone and say, "Roberson, I know that is you. What do you want?"

No man understands me because this is for edification, mine. If it were meant for interpretation, then someone would understand it.

This is why we get mixed up. There are four major diversities of tongues.

The first is the one most of you are familiar with. It is the one you receive when hands are laid on you, the power falls on you, and you speak. That is tongues for personal edification. It is the basic power diversity of tongues.

The second is tongues for interpretation, given in a public assembly for the sole purpose of interpretation.

The third is tongues that extend into the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit and empower the believer to stand in the gap for his life, his family, his city, and his nation.

The fourth is tongues that present themselves as a sign to the unbeliever.

I was stuck on that one. I said, "God, how can tongues be a sign to an unbeliever?" The Bible is very clear that if you speak in tongues out of order, it is a sign to the unbeliever that you are stark raving mad.

In India, my interpreter, Dr. Philip, spoke several dialects, English included. I had a morning off and went to see a Buddhist temple. He grabbed the Buddhist temple guide, who also spoke English, and began speaking in tongues to him.

The poor guide's eyes got big, and he backed up. Dr. Philip pressed in on him, speaking in tongues. Finally the guide said in English, "What are you doing?"

He said, "I am speaking in a language God has given me."

"What are you saying?"

"I do not know. It is a sign to the unbeliever."

Then he asked, "Do you want to be born again?"

The man said, "Yes, yes, get him off me."

When is tongues a sign to the unbeliever? When it transcends your intellect and empowers you to speak any language on the face of this earth that you had no previous knowledge of, like on the day of Pentecost.

That has happened to me seven times in eleven years.

But you do not have to worry about that until you first familiarize yourself with the one He gave freely that works inward, called edification.

In Sacramento, I was on a half-secular television station. I did not know if they even allowed speaking with tongues, but who cared? It felt so good that I just let it go.

The television host asked, "Brother Roberson, what is the most changing thing?"

I said, "The love walk."

I began preaching on 1 Corinthians 13, that love never fails and seeks not her own. I was working that camera over. All of a sudden, I heard tongues rolling out of my spirit. It almost jumped out before I could stop it.

I looked at the host, and he did not do anything. I thought, "If he is not going to stop me, I am not going to stop." I thought there would be an interpretation when it was done.

I finished, and nothing happened. Nobody did anything. Everybody acted like nothing happened.

After the program, a woman came running over and asked, "Brother Roberson, where did you learn German from the old country?"

I said, "I hardly know English from the new."

She said, "You mean you do not know what happened? I am the only German-speaking counselor. I got a phone call from a German community in Sacramento. A woman said you preached directly to her, that even though she was dying of cancer and bloated and swollen, if she would accept Jesus and touch the television, she would be healed. She went out under the power and got up with no more bloat."

I said, "God, I preached in fluent German. If I am the last one to find out about this anymore, I want a raise."

In Anaheim, I called out a Spanish lady and told her what was wrong with her. She was very agreeable, and I thought, "Roberson, you are right on tonight." I did not know she barely understood any English.

Tongues busted out of my spirit. I did not know that I began addressing her in perfect Spanish, telling her God was healing her and ministering to her by His Spirit. Then I stopped, she asked me a question, and I answered her question in Spanish.

She fell down on the floor, so I left. Conversation over.

Later they told me what happened. Would she have done a double take if she had known she was talking directly to the Holy Ghost?

Another time, in Florida, every time I said something, a man on the third row leaned over and whispered to his friend. I thought, "That is rude." After a while, the one man waved the other one off and sat there listening.

The pastor later told me the man spoke French and had brought his own interpreter so he could enjoy the service. About one-fourth through my message, he said I started preaching in perfect French, so he told the interpreter to stop.

Nobody else heard French. They heard the message in English, word for word. He was the only one who heard French.

It is one thing for God to take over and preach any message He wants through you. It is another thing when God becomes your personal interpreter.

Again, you do not have to worry about that operation of power until you first familiarize yourself with tongues for personal edification.

Tongues for personal edification is the only gift of the Spirit that can be operated at your own will.

That does not mean you control God. Nobody controls God. But He made you the steward of this gift because the edification is inward. All the other gifts are for the edification of others outward. This one is inward and is activated at your own will.

"You mean I can speak in tongues any time I want to?"

You certainly do not do it when you do not want to.

Somebody says, "I can only speak with tongues when I am in a service and the anointing is so heavy that a little tear begins to trickle down my cheek."

What do you mean the only time you can talk in tongues is when you are crying? Give me a hammer and we will beat you up. We will get you crying and edifying. Better to have hammer marks than die of cancer.

Tongues for personal edification is the gift that works inward for your own personal edification.

As of yet, we have found out from Jude that when we pray in the Holy Ghost, this diversity of tongues builds us up on our most holy faith, above a walk where the senses rule as king and bring us to a dead standstill.

An infirmity is when you know from Genesis to Revelation that He has borne your sicknesses and carried your pains, but as God is your witness, you cannot get that damnable thing off your body. That, my friend, is an infirmity.

At that point, people make a new denomination that says, "God put the disease on you to work something out in your life."

Baloney. Double baloney.

Just because your senses have brought you to a dead standstill is no sign there is not a way by the Holy Spirit to approach that Word and cause a merger of the life that is in it. Jesus said:

The words that I speak unto you,
they are spirit,
and they are life.

There is a way to activate them and cause them to come alive in you until there is nothing this side of hell the devil can do about it.

The Spirit spoke:

"In this day the former move shall be like child's play, for My children will come up higher and higher and higher in Me. There is a walk where a man walks free, empowered by My Spirit. This is the way I would have you be, as a light, a sign, and a wonder, saith the Spirit of Christ."

We know that prayer in the Holy Ghost will build us up on our most holy faith, above a sense-dominated walk. But how does praying in tongues do this? Why am I edified?

If Jude 20 had been enough for you at face value, you would have been a whole lot further along than you are. Faith is something we have almost labeled elusive. We have cried for it, bawled for it, offered to do anything God wanted for it, and confessed for it until our tongues almost fell out of our mouths.

Yet right under our noses has been a verse that gives you and me that ironclad guarantee.

Face value was not enough for me. I said, "God, I want this to do all over the world what it has done for me. I am hungry, but now I can walk into the power of God, out of everything You said I am free from and into everything You said I am, just because I want to."

First Corinthians 14:2 says:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God:
for no man understandeth him;
howbeit in the spirit
he speaketh mysteries.

"Howbeit" is analytical. It analyzes the verse. If we are speaking in tongues, nobody understands us, and yet we are talking to God, then what is the purpose of it?

Paul used that word so he could give the answer.

I was shaking when I approached this verse because I knew I was finally going to have the answer.

He said:

In the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

Within that one word, "mysteries," was the whole reason you and I experience an increase of faith from praying in tongues.

I explored that word until my meditator almost fell on the ground. I found out that the word "mysteries" in the Greek pertains to the mysteries hidden in God from the foundations of the world, but now made available to you and me, the new creation who are filled with the Holy Ghost.

I said, "Wait a minute, God. I am starting to smell an increase of faith. You mean when I speak in tongues, I am communicating up before God, before the throne room, the same mysteries that have been hidden in God since before the world was? The same mysteries pertaining to everything Jesus Christ is to me and through me?"

The same redemptive mysteries that were hidden in God before the cross are the mysteries I am speaking. They are the same mysteries Paul was made a minister of.

How could Paul minister these mysteries had he not first understood them?

Paul said:

I thank my God,
I speak with tongues more than ye all.

He was responsible for three-quarters of the revelation knowledge recorded in the New Testament, especially in the areas of grace.

I can see him hour after hour communicating those divine secrets and mysteries before the throne room, God responding like any other prayer and answering his prayer. All of a sudden his spirit came alive with illumination and understanding to the degree that he picked up a quill, put it in an inkwell, and recorded the letter God gave him. God thought so much of it that He made it an epistle, a permanent part of the Word of God.

You are not edified because you are speaking to some mysterious electrical charge according to a law of physics. You are edified because you are speaking before the throne room the very same mysteries and understandings recorded in the epistles that were so hard to understand that Peter even said, concerning Paul's writings, "This stuff is heavy."

This verse started happening to me. I would spend extended amounts of time praying in the Holy Ghost. Then I would open my Bible and meditate. Suddenly I would get to a verse I had read ten thousand times, and something would go off on the inside of me.

I would say, "Oh my God, I did not know that said that."

I would run and get my deacon, Earl Hitz, and say, "Earl, look at this. Can you see what this means?"

I would explain it and explain it. He would look at me and say, "I think I am getting it, Davy. Keep going."

I would say, "How come you cannot see that?"

I thought God was revealing it to me because I was a preacher, and if He did not talk to me, what would I say when I came out?

There was another reason. It is one thing to say, "He has borne my sicknesses and carried my pains." It is another thing to have that mystery born on the inside of you to such a degree that faith comes by hearing, and hearing, and hearing by the Word of what the Spirit in the Word says about it.

When that goes off on the inside of you, there is not anything this side of hell the devil can do about it.

When that goes off on the inside of you, you are going through, and nobody can stop you.